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André Jansson

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ARTICLE

The Mediatization of Consumption

Towards an analytical framework of image culture

ANDRÉ JANSSON

Malmö University

Abstract. Although the concepts of 'media culture' and 'consumer culture' have been commonly used as labels for contemporary society, they have rarely been explicitly compared. Nor have there been any serious attempts to clarify whether, or how, socio-cultural change is fusing them together. In this article it is argued that transitory processes such as culturalization, mediatization and simulation – which may all be compiled within the notion of reflexive accumulation – make it almost pointless to keep the concepts apart. Rather, in contemporary western societies it is possible to discern the rise of *image culture*. This is a socio-cultural state in which media images and media-influenced commodity-signs are to an increasing extent used as sources for, and expressions of, cultural identity. Hence, it is also argued that image culture must not be confused with the postmodernist hypothesis of cultural implosion. Rather, the maintenance of image culture presupposes the hermeneutic activities of social actors.

Key words

consumer culture • everyday life • image culture • intertextuality • media culture • mediatization • reflexive accumulation • simulation

THE TERM 'REFLEXIVE ACCUMULATION' refers to a condition in which economic and cultural processes are more closely interwoven than in earlier phases of modern capitalism. As theorists such as Lash and Urry (1994) have argued, industrial production is increasingly a matter of symbolic circulation – a matter of responding to, or creating, semiotic rather than functional

needs. On the one hand, this means that profit making demands a greater sensitivity to the hermeneutics of everyday life. On the other hand, it means that the expressivity of social actors is increasingly intertwined with economic activity, embedded in consumption. So while the economy gets culturalized, cultural life gets commercialized.

This is no longer a very original argument but it is an increasingly valid one. Yet, although most theoretical work on reflexive accumulation, as well as on post-Fordism, emphasizes the interplay between industrial economics and social hermeneutics, there is still too little understanding of how these processes are actually perceived by social subjects. Notably, there is a lack of empirical research trying to reveal the socio-semiotic mechanisms according to which the webs of commercial images are appropriated and negotiated in everyday life. So far, there are primarily two research areas within cultural studies that have touched upon these issues. First, there is a growing body of research dealing with consumer culture and everyday life, involving analyses of the cultural experience and expressivity of consumption (e.g. Bourdieu, 1984[1979]; Lunt and Livingstone, 1992; Miller et al., 1998). Second, there is a quite wide-ranging field of audience studies investigating various aspects of media consumption through ethnographic fieldwork (e.g. Silverstone and Hirsch, 1992; Moores, 1996; Tufte, 2000) and reception analysis (e.g. Morley, 1980; Radway, 1987; Press, 1991). What is missing, then, is empirical work that explicitly fuses these areas together – analyses of consumption that pay sufficient attention to the significance of the media.

There is no reason today to exclude the media from consumption studies. Nor is there any self-evident reason to treat media consumption as a separate case. Due to the mediatization process, which is integral to reflexive accumulation, most kinds of consumer goods have become increasingly image-loaded, taking on meanings in relation to media texts, other commodity-signs, entire lifestyles, and so on. As Jameson (1991) notes in a discussion of the symbiosis between the market and the media, the ‘products sold on the market become the very content of the media image’ (p. 275). In such a context, consuming goods and media texts becomes pretty much the same thing. Earlier distinctions between thing and concept erode, and ultimately the real world gives way to a realm of postmodern simulation – at least on a theoretical level.

The present article is yet one more theoretical comment upon this development. However, it is also a discursive prelude to empirical analyses that will investigate in greater detail how media consumption weaves together with other forms of consumption, thus exposing the inseparability

of these two domains.¹ The overarching aim of this text is thus to provide a conceptual platform for cultural analysis and, as an extension, to indicate why media studies and consumption studies must be joined. The argumentation includes four main components.

First, I propose that we problematize the relationship between 'consumer culture' and 'media culture'. Due to the division of academic labour, the relationship between these two concepts has rarely been made explicit. My argument is that it is no longer possible to make any substantial distinction between them; in the era of reflexive accumulation they collapse into one another. And in order to capture the nature of this condition empirically, it is better to speak of *image culture* – a socio-cultural state in which the kind of confusions expressed in postmodern theory are more or less self-generating.

Second, I illustrate the emergence of image culture in terms of three complementary processes: *culturalization*, *mediatization* and *simulation*. In so doing, I aim to delineate the macro-structural forces that give shape to people's everyday lives, and simultaneously point to the possibilities of uniting postmodern theory with a theory of reflexive accumulation.

Third, I try to specify the semiotic mode that is fostered by reflexive accumulation. As stated earlier, everyday life is (more or less) formed in relation to industrially encoded webs of commodity-signs. Hence, in order to understand the contemporary ambiguity of concepts like 'medium' and 'consumption', it is necessary to assess the mechanisms of *commercial intertextuality* – the continuous cross-references through which the meanings of signs and texts are fixed and renegotiated.

Finally, in order to advance a framework for analysing the social significance of image culture, all these developments will be connected to the contexts of *everyday life*. I assert that commercial intertextuality cannot be understood in a social vacuum, or as a means of capitalist control. Cultural meanings and social implications are always negotiated in relation to a number of contextual parameters. Hence, this turn to the real-life context involves a plea for further investigations of how postmodern transformations within the representational sphere are actually interpreted and evaluated by people themselves.

UNDERSTANDING MEDIA CULTURE AND CONSUMER CULTURE

In cultural studies, as well as in public debate, the terms 'media culture' and 'consumer culture' often figure as buzz words. They seem to signify intriguing yet taken-for-granted aspects of contemporary society. However, since they have rarely been explicitly compared, there is no clear understanding

of the extent to which they actually refer to one and the same thing – that is, how much they overlap in theory. And, consequently, there is just as little understanding of the extent to which social and cultural processes have fused them even closer together. I argue that reflexive accumulation contributes to an acceleration of such a fusion, disabling potential theoretical distinctions.

In order to strengthen this argument, one must of course assess what ‘media culture’ and ‘consumer culture’ may stand for in the first place. My purpose is not to present a literary survey of the multiple meanings that have been ascribed to these concepts over the years. Nor do I intend to develop theoretical definitions that are absolute, since such an operation would contradict my underlying belief that both media culture and consumer culture are dynamic structures. Rather, in spite of divergences in previous definitions of these two concepts, my aim is to demonstrate their compatibility within cultural studies. And the means of demonstrating this compatibility is to propose a shared view of their common denominator: *culture*.

As many theorists have illuminated (see Williams, 1981: 10–14; Thompson, 1990: 122–62; Bocock, 1992: 234), the concept of culture may point to different dimensions of society and is therefore relevant within different areas of research. However, going back to the roots of cultural studies, it is reasonable to focus upon the interaction between *cultural products*, *cultural communities* and *cultural practices*. Rather than treating them as alternative definitions, they must be conceived of as three cultural spheres, or three interrelated components of ‘a whole way of life’, following Raymond Williams (1961):

I would then define the theory of culture as the study of relationships between elements in a whole way of life. The analysis of culture is the attempt to discover the nature of the organization which is the complex of these relationships. . . . A key-word, in such analysis, is pattern: it is with the discovery of patterns of a characteristic kind that any useful cultural analysis begins, and it is with the relationships between these patterns, which sometimes reveal unexpected identities and correspondences in hitherto separately considered activities, sometimes again reveal discontinuities of an unexpected kind, that general cultural analysis is concerned. (pp. 46–7)

When Williams introduced this perspective, which is still a foundation for the entire cultural studies paradigm, it implied that many societal aspects that had previously been left out of analyses of culture (primarily limited

to literary criticism, musical analyses, etc.) had to be included – notably aspects regarding the practices and relationships of everyday life. The turn to everyday life recognizes that ‘the cultural’, or what is *meaningful* to people, can be found wherever there is communication and social interaction, and hence not only in artistic expressions, or in recorded form. As Hall (1971) states, following Williams’ perspective, culture is clearly about ‘the way social life is experienced and handled, the meanings and values which inform human action, which are embodied in and mediate social relations, political life, etc.’ (p. 6) – that is, *the interplay between signification and interpretation*. Through this hermeneutic dynamic, products, communities and practices become cultural.

Hence, culture is not a pre-given or independent category, but arises through people’s hermeneutic praxis – ongoing meaning production that never reaches any ultimate conclusion or completion. In a similar manner, Clifford Geertz in his classical essay, ‘Thick Description’ (1993[1973]) considers culture to be ‘webs of significance’ spun between people through their own social actions (p. 5). Thus, what is pointed out here is that cultural praxis (referring to both signification and interpretation) cannot be described as being without structure. Since ‘the cultural’ emanates from people’s wishes to understand each other, it cannot arise in a social vacuum, but only through symbolic exchange between people. Continuous cultural praxis both presupposes and creates more or less structured webs of significance – that is, interpretative communities (Fish, 1980). The existence of such communities is the very foundation of people’s ability to attain a certain degree of intersubjective understanding and to maintain a sense of cultural identity. In other words, there is a mutual relationship between cultural practices and cultural (interpretative) communities; neither of these categories can exist without the other.

In the same way as social practices become meaningful as they enter into webs of significance, so do various kinds of objects. Cultural products are those material and immaterial human creations which, in subjective experience and in relation to a context, function as signs – that is, as representations of something more than just their mere physical, sensory properties. Throughout social life, objects appear as components and outcomes of cultural practice and cultural communities; they become important for the creation of webs of significance, and through the very same processes they themselves become culturally meaningful. As Douglas and Isherwood (1978) argue in *The World of Goods*, as soon as an object is produced and used within a cultural context the mere functional dimension is supplemented by a symbolic dimension:

If it is said that the essential function of language is its capacity for poetry, we shall assume that the essential function of consumption is its capacity to make sense. Forget the idea of consumer irrationality. Forget that commodities are good for eating, clothing, and shelter; forget their usefulness and try instead the idea that commodities are good for thinking; treat them as a nonverbal medium for the creative faculty. (p. 62)

This quote indicates that it is possible to treat the material environment as an information system. A pair of sunglasses turns into something more than a protection device for one's eyes, and a bicycle turns into something more than a vehicle for transportation. In every society, objects enter into complex systems of cultural categories which are established and negotiated through the social interaction between people (see also Bourdieu, 1984[1979]). Accordingly, this view underlines my previous statement that all cultural phenomena spring from the interplay between signification and interpretation – an interplay which is both based on and contributes to the negotiation of shared cultural meanings. Every choice between material and immaterial products is the result of, and contributes to, culture. Cultural meaning is not carried naturally within the object itself; it is not totally fixed or pre-given, but rather developed within the processes of production, exchange and use. Following Baudrillard (1998[1973]), one may argue that the code systems developed through these processes enable people to construct and reconstruct cultural expression through the combination and recombination of commodities: 'The circulation, purchase, sale, appropriation of differentiated goods and signs/objects today constitute our language, our code, the code by which the entire society *communicates* and converses' (pp. 79–80).

What unites media culture and consumer culture, then, is that both concepts deal with the hermeneutic processes through which *consumer products* (that is, *commodities*) and *media products* become cultural (via their incorporation within webs of significance) and, conversely, how these products enter into and become influential for the formation of webs of significance as such. The concepts refer to a socio-cultural condition in which commodities and media texts are important for the establishment and expression of cultural communities (webs of significance) and hence also for the creation and expression of cultural identity (see Jansson, 2001b). In other words, the concepts refer to a condition in which these products-as-texts saturate and give shape to culture as a 'whole way of life'. Neither media culture nor consumer culture can be reduced to only products,

practices or communities, but involve the very interrelationship between these three spheres.

Yet, the *potential distinction* between consumer culture (or commodity culture) and media culture may be traced to the product level, the circulated objects-as-texts, since this is where the concepts diverge. Clear definitions of the properties of 'consumer products' and 'media products' might thus generate an understanding of the difference between consumer culture and media culture. But how do we actually distinguish media products from consumer products? Most media products are also commodities. And, given the culturalist perspective outlined earlier, most kinds of commodities do in some way function as mediators of meaning. Notably, the emergence of reflexive accumulation actualizes all these ambiguities, making it increasingly pointless to distinguish between such categories. While there indeed have existed, and still exist, consumer goods with hardly any cultural meaning beyond their functional purpose, as well as non-commodified media products, they are not representative of the culture of reflexive modernity. Rather, they are all embedded in complex intertextual patterns, which in turn interact with the practices and communities of everyday life. They are part of a developing *image culture*.

Hence, my point is that every attempt to make further distinctions would be misleading. It is impossible to find any functional limits to 'consumption' or 'mediation'.² What is important to make clear, rather, is that media culture and consumer culture are *theoretically overlapping* and *empirically inseparable* categories. On the one hand, the scope of media culture is expanding, simultaneously changing the face of consumer culture. Mediated texts mean a great deal for the way people experience the relationship between self and the surrounding world, including the world of goods. The cultural naming of consumer goods is normally impossible to discuss and analyse without taking into account how such a process is related to the circulation and appropriation of media images. Surprisingly, Bourdieu (1984[1979]) and Douglas and Isherwood (1978) pay very limited, if any, attention to how the media environment influences cultural classifications. As demonstrated in media ethnographic research, though, the everyday media context actually constitutes an integral part of socio-cultural processes, rather than something external to them.³

On the other hand, the ongoing refinement and implementation of the capitalist logic involves a commodification process within the media sector. This tendency can be found in studies of how contemporary public service media actually function, and of how intensified competition in the circulation of the 'audience commodity', in the shape of audience ratings, has

affected their practices, their ways of communicating.⁴ It can also be discerned in relation to new forms of commodified interactivity through which audiences are encouraged to take part in (and pay for) the mediation process itself. For example, more and more TV shows have interactive components, such as gaming, voting, commentary, etc., which always require some kind of payment. As economic and cultural processes collapse into one another, the distinction between consumption and mediation vanishes as well. That is the very core of the capitalist image culture.

PRODUCING AND CONSUMING IMAGES: THREE TRANSITORY PROCESSES

The second part of my argument suggests that the emergence of image culture can best be understood in light of the socio-economic changes associated with *reflexive accumulation*. The notion that consumption is just as much about communication as about functional use value cannot in itself be treated as a sign of a new era. As stated earlier, objects may always communicate in social contexts. And it was actually during the Fordist era of mass production that consumption initially became a matter of *style*; and style became an essential social task. Since mass production enabled more people to afford the commodified symbols of the good life, the entire cultural value system was set in faster motion (see Riesman, 1950; Ewen, 1999: 57–77).

However, as theorists such as Lash, Urry, Harvey and Jameson have argued, the transformation from Fordism to post-Fordism, and eventually to a mode of reflexive accumulation, involves an accentuation of these tendencies. I am even inclined to assert that symbolic production has conformed to Baudrillard's postmodern theories of the 1970s to 1980s – a development enabled by the expansion of new media and communication technologies and the parallel expansion of media industries. I now outline some of the main characteristics of this epochal shift under the three headings of *culturalization*, *mediatization* and *simulation*.

Culturalization

If it is possible to argue that the production of culture has been removed from the sphere of everyday life into profit-making institutions – that is, the culture industry (see Adorno, 1991) – it is at the same time important to note that the production of 'functional' commodities has become culturalized. Today, the production of such things takes place within organizational settings which have adopted many of the characteristics associated with the culture industry – particularly the preoccupation with meaning

creation – and hence the borderlines between the culture industry and other industrial branches (including all those branches normally not considered as cultural producers, like the car industry or the soap industry) have become blurred. Of course, there have long been corporate branches with ambivalent connections to the culture industry, such as most kinds of fashion production, in which the work of designers and artists has been an indispensable ingredient. But today these branches seem to be the norm rather than exceptions to the rule. In order to make a profit, most producers of consumer goods have to put great resources into the development of an image that will hopefully make the product distinguishable from other, basically similar, products on the market. Thus, in vast areas of the marketplace, involving a vast range of product categories, the modern ideal of rational progress has become increasingly obsolete as a sales argument (Leiss et al., 1997: 236–62; Klein, 2000).

However, as argued, for example, by Harvey (1990), there is no reason to believe that the culturalized economy represents a significant break from the basic organizing principles of capitalist economic life. Although the means of accumulation have taken on a new form, the ultimate goal of profit making is still predominant. The transformation of the production system can be explained according to the same capitalist logic that motivated the rise of Fordism. Due to the influence of a number of interconnected political and economic factors during the late 1960s and early 1970s, the Fordist mode of production proved to be too rigid for generating the surplus value needed to sustain economic growth in the western, and notably the US, economies. The prime means of solving this problem was to put a higher premium on rationalization and organizational restructuring – trying to eliminate ‘the rigidity of long-term and large-scale fixed capital investments in mass production systems that precluded much flexibility of design and presumed stable growth in invariant consumer markets’ (p. 142). The mode of production that started to emerge was one of *flexible accumulation*, or, in more general terms, *post-Fordism*, outlined for example by Lash and Urry (1987) and Harvey (1990).

This is not to say that Fordism in its entirety, globally, or in any clear-cut manner, is replaced by a pure post-Fordist economy. However, following Harvey (1990: 173–88) and others, there are at least two points marking the last 25 years’ development, which are also crucial for the understanding of image culture. First, mass production of homogeneous, standardized goods is replaced by flexible small-batch production of a variety of product types. Second, resource-driven production is replaced by demand-driven production. Thus, culturalization is closely connected to a wider process of

dematerialization, which means that a decreasing share of industrial business is about concrete material production. And the prominence of design, packaging and advertising – what Wernick (1991) refers to as ‘promotion’ – is intrinsically bound up with the implementation of rationalizing technologies, such as computers and robots, and new communication technologies which enable the alteration and variation of product characteristics (customization) demanded by an increasingly heterogeneous and reflexive consumer market.

Moreover, following Lash and Urry (1994), the phenomenon of dematerialization extends well beyond the sphere of production (see also Slater, 1997: 193–4). The fact that non-material goods play a more important role in the economy, and that material commodities have a greater non-material component, is also reflected at the level of everyday experience. Due to the development of mass media, people today are to a great extent encountering semiotic representations of commodities, rather than the commodities themselves. In the course of everyday life, various kinds of media texts provide consumers with images of goods and services that might be acquired and incorporated as meaningful components of their expressive style. Consumers often have a quite extensive knowledge of the meanings of things before they actually acquire them.

When Lash and Urry (1994) introduced the concept of *reflexive accumulation* (as a modification of ‘flexible accumulation’) it was precisely this broader socio-cultural picture they were addressing. According to Lash and Urry, the notion of flexibility does not capture ‘the extent to which production has become increasingly grounded in discursive knowledge’, and ‘the extent to which symbolic processes, including an important aesthetic component, have permeated both consumption *and* production’ (pp. 60–1). This means that the culturalization process is based on the continuous hermeneutic interplay between consumption and production practices. As lifestyle engineering has become a reflexive project, a similar self-reflexivity has developed among producers (see also Wernick, 1991). Accordingly, compared to ‘flexible accumulation’, the term ‘reflexive accumulation’ is also better suited to capture the increasing significance of the media – the means for circulating discursive knowledge.

Mediatization

In the modern world, a large part of people’s cultural frameworks is derived from media consumption. One may say that the mass media provide a means for individuals to map out and elaborate their position in time and space. In the realm of culture, the term mediatization refers to the process through

which mediated cultural products have gained importance as cultural referents and hence contribute to the development and maintenance of cultural communities. In other words, the mediatization of culture is the process that reinforces and expands the realm of media culture.

What is particularly interesting to note regarding the mediatization process is that the diversified constitution of the contemporary media system caters simultaneously for the extension and culmination of modern socio-cultural processes, and for their over-extension and lapse into post-modernism. In the modern context, the mass media's potential to create and nourish cultural communities has often been discussed in relation to already demarcated social groups, for example 'the British people' (see Scannell, 1992) or 'the European people' (see Morley and Robins, 1995). Through the use of mass media, these kinds of groups have been given adequate cultural material to reinforce a sense of shared cultural identity. The typical example in this context is the older function of national broadcasting. As the range of programming was very limited for a long time in most European countries, both television and radio could gather vast national audiences to watch or listen to the same content. To use Benedict Anderson's (1983) term; people became part of an 'imagined community'.

However, since the media system has become more international and market-driven, the patterns are very different today. The media not only nourish pre-existing cultural communities; to an increasing extent they also contribute to the establishment of new, *detrterritorialized* ones (see Meyrowitz, 1985: 131–49; Featherstone, 1995: 114–22; Thompson, 1995: 207–34). While it has become more difficult to maintain national or other locally fixed cultural communities – since the differentiated media output instead sustains a polarization between specialized audience segments (Reimer, 1998) – people can experience a new sense of community through the sharing of lifestyles and certain cultural tastes. Such communities are typically transnational and established in relation to popular culture, including advertising and consumer goods. In this regard, the media function as an 'image bank' from which individuals may adopt specific cultural attributes according to lifestyle (see Kellner, 1995: 257). This is particularly true of the visual media: while the media, in general, support the development of *detrterritorialized cultural communities*, the visual media play a crucial role in the development of *expressive communities* (see Featherstone, 1991: 66–72; Gibbins and Reimer, 1999). These are communities that are not merely based on invisible denominators like values, interests, demographic characteristics, etc., but also, and sometimes exclusively, on semiotic expressions of a shared interpretative framework.

Furthermore, mediatization has also influenced, and coincided with, other spheres of commodity production. As Harvey (1990: 284–9) notes in his discussion of the term *time–space compression*, the development of electronic communication technologies has been essential for the speeding up of information flows, both within and between corporations and customers. Reflexive utilization of media resources contributes to accentuating the fluidity of fashions and styles. In social life, this means that cultural and expressive communities are not only spatially displaced and increasingly pluralized, but also increasingly *volatile*. New cultural components enter and vanish from people's cultural horizons more and more frequently. Electronic media implicate a shortcut between 'producers' and 'consumers', penetrating the lifeworld as a kind of cultural, or aesthetic, expert system (Lash and Urry, 1994: 54). Of course, this does not mean that cultural producers are simply handing out new trends to passive consumers, or, conversely, merely responding to new trends. Rather, reflexive accumulation implies that producers are both sensitive to cultural impulses and able to adjust and display these trends to potential consumers.

However, as Jameson (1991) argues, since the growing authority of image and style is basically an outcome of (late) capitalism, there is also a certain socio-economic logic to this cultural transformation. First of all, a driving force behind the 'popularization' of innovative styles is the cultural and economic interests of the culture industries, notably the cultural intermediaries (see Featherstone, 1991). Second, the absorption of different kinds of alternative styles by the cultural industries tends to promote a state of middle-class hegemony. Although traditional value hierarchies are problematized, blurring the lines between legitimate and illegitimate cultural forms and tastes, the same process also involves the symbolic disarming of countercultural movements. In sum, the ephemeral character of culture that arises from mediatization involves, on the one hand, an increased stylistic freedom among consumers, and, on the other hand, a growing potential for producers to convert new concepts to commercial advantage – including those of oppressed and oppositional groups (Harvey, 1990: 289; Jameson, 1991: 49; Klein, 2000). The latter condition stresses that mediatization in itself generates commodification.

Simulation

The argument that ultimately follows from the identification of culturalization and mediatization processes is that today we live in a world of spectacle and simulations. According to postmodernist perspectives, most notably represented by Baudrillard, media images and the appearances of

commodities now outweigh the significance of direct experiences and functional use-values. When images become more important than their referents, when the copy precedes the original, the simulacrum rules the world. Reality is no longer a dependable category.

However, Baudrillard's argument is not entirely new. Rather, it is to be seen as an extreme philosophical extension of Marx's theory of commodity fetishism and Benjamin's descriptions of metropolitan consumerist phantasmagoria. Between these endpoints – the Marxist and the postmodernist – it is also possible to identify the theories of the spectacle, introduced by the French neo-Marxist and Situationist movements of the 1960s, headed by figures like Henri Lefebvre and Guy Debord. As Best and Kellner (1997) argue, there is a clear theoretical trajectory 'from the society of the *commodity* to the society of the *spectacle* to the society of the *simulacrum*, paralleled by increasing commodification and massification to the point of implosion of the key phenomena described by modern theory' (p. 80).

The shift from early Marxism to the neo-Marxist/Situationist standpoint is essentially a reorientation from production to consumption, or from the factory to everyday life. While still adhering to a Marxist interpretation of society, Debord (1994[1967]) argues in *The Society of the Spectacle* that the dominant force of alienation is no longer the mere commodity, produced in factories by workers, but the spectacle, primarily generated by symbolic producers in the culture industry. Parallel to the Frankfurt School's ideas of the capitalist expropriation of people's 'free time', Debord asserts that 'alienated consumption is added to alienated production as an inescapable duty of the masses' (p. 29). Yet, the emerging forms of consumption, predominantly governed by the mechanisms of commercialized media culture, are not concerned with use-value in its original sense, but with the illusion of use-value; what things *seem* to be, and what solutions they *seem* to provide. This is also what Lefebvre (1971) refers to as the creation of *make-believe* (pp. 85–98). If industrial society created false needs in the form of a widespread urge to *have* certain things, the society of the spectacle is a social arrangement marked by an extreme preoccupation with how things *appear*. According to Debord, the spectacle is most clearly manifested in the fact that the use-value of commodities is judged to an increasing extent according to their style and surface.

As a student of Lefebvre, Baudrillard was clearly inspired by the Situationists. However, when the notion of the spectacle is explicitly brought up in Baudrillard's (1983a) subsequent writings on *simulation* and simulacra, it is in a negative sense. Now, from his postmodern point of view, the cultural transition has gone even further:

We are no longer in the society of the spectacle which the Situationists talked about, nor in the specific types of alienation and repression which this implied. The medium itself is no longer identifiable as such, and the merging of the medium and the message is the first great formula of this new age. (p. 54)

Such a hyper-extension of the mediatization process denotes that the products of the media system no longer provide people with information about reality. Rather, media images constitute a hyperreality more significant than reality itself. Day after day, people are bombarded with 'information' and images, which cannot be judged according to established norms of truth and falsehood; the media flow forces itself upon people's lived experience and *becomes* reality itself. Consequently, there no longer exist any media in the original sense, but merely commercial apparatuses producing simulacra for an imaginary mass audience. The over-amplification of appearance and dramaturgy correlates with the implosion of meaning; communication is exhausted in the moment of its own performance (Baudrillard, 1983b: 97–100). Compared to the Situationists, then, Baudrillard no longer discusses Marxist phenomena such as alienation since, ultimately, there are no real points of reference to get alienated from. Likewise, Debord's distinction between appearance and reality vanishes since reality is no longer identifiable.

When uncoupled from any modern anchorage in objective reality or pre-existing needs or use-values, signifiers take on meanings by themselves according to new associative schemes. There is no longer any stable signified which can lead subjects to relevant, clear-cut interpretations; the images saturating everyday life refer to other mediated images, which are in themselves uncoupled from referents in the real world. Self-referentiality among fragmentary images generates floating interpretations according to a non-narrative logic. As many cultural analysts have pointed out (e.g. Foster, 1983; Kaplan, 1987: 33–48; Jameson, 1991: 67–96; Kellner, 1995; Fiske, 1996), such a postmodern aesthetic, or anti-aesthetic, is regularly manifested in advertising, fashion and music videos. This is also where we enter the realm of commercial intertextuality.

COMMERCIAL INTERTEXTUALITY – ENCODING/DECODING/ RE-ENCODING

As my discussion has shown so far, reflexive accumulation gives rise to a situation in which the struggle for meaning intensifies. Mutual reflexivity among producers and consumers implies that the distinction between

'producer' and 'consumer', or between 'encoder' and 'decoder' (see Hall, 1980), is blurred. Through the rapid circulation of images, closer and closer webs of intertextuality are spun, continuously created and re-created. In the following two sections I turn first to the encoding policies of the industry and then stress the need for contextualized analyses of consumption as decoding/re-encoding.

Industrial strategy

When a particular product is consumed, the object, as well as the practice, is interpreted according to standards which are greatly influenced by media images, not just advertising, but also images created in other media texts. If, for example, a particular commodity is regularly positioned in fashionable, urban contexts when depicted in magazines, movies and TV series, this view may be cultivated among the audience. The meaning of a particular act of consumption emerges to a great extent via the connotative link between the consumed object and the media-generated image – like one text related to another. The image, often based upon several different texts, is *inscribed* in the commodity in the same way that many different discourses may be at play within one and the same media text. This is what *intertextuality* is all about; the internal co-existence and referentiality of various externally derived texts, genres and discourses. As demonstrated by Fairclough (1995), most media texts include aspects and traces of several other textual phenomena (see also Fiske, 1989; Collins, 1992; Agger, 1999; Bjurström et al., 2000: 109–12). As Hebdige (1981) points out in the case of the fashion for streamlining that spread, in the 1930s, from cars, trains, etc. to the surfaces of a range of unrelated products, an intertextual analysis of consumer goods would lead to similar conclusions.

To be sure, the image industry wants to maintain control of how these semiotic webs are spun. A good illustration of industrially encoded intertextuality is the *product placement*, which is essentially a strategy of positioning a branded product within a desirable media context, trying to strengthen the image of the product. For example, in ABC's new docu-soap, *The Runner*, the sponsors even determine the plot. The participants' mission is to cross the American continent without getting captured, regularly completing tasks like 'eating a Big Mac in Illinois'. As Russell (1998) notes, product placement always contains a dual movement. First, there is an intertextual linkage directed from a media text to a branded consumer product, which implies that the styles and values of the media text are transferred to the product. Second, there is a linkage directed from the product to the media text. The image, or the 'aura', of the commodity

contributes to the perceived characteristics of people and places in the film or TV programme.

However, broadening the scope of Russell's analysis, I would assert that this two-way transfer of cultural meaning is also to be found in other categories than particular media texts and particular branded products. For example, a great deal of contemporary popular culture illustrates entire lifestyles, including consumption styles, without necessarily mentioning certain brands. These kinds of lifestyle representations, characteristic of postmodern texts, are likewise based on a play with textual conventions and the images of various consumer products (see Foster, 1983; Kaplan, 1987; Wernick, 1991; Collins, 1992; Kellner, 1995; Fowles, 1996: 90–93; Nixon, 1997). In this way, commercial intertextuality largely functions unnoticed. Image formation is a matter of *cultivation* (see Gerbner, 1969), emanating from a composite message system composed of a variety of interrelated texts, genres and discourses. This means that even non-commercial media (such as organizational and public service broadcasting) are part of these intertextual processes. On the one hand, non-commercial corporations have successively adapted many of the features of the commercial sphere, such as new programme formats (purchased from commercial format companies), new genres and the inclusion of sponsor messages. On the other hand, while trying to keep their distance from the commercial sector, the distributors of alternative media (typically non-commercial organizations) are often imitated by the culture industry, which continually searches for new concepts and styles to exploit through re-encoding.

We can now see how commercial intertextuality is related to the three processes listed earlier: (1) it can be explained as the dominant semiotic mode of a culturalized economy; (2) it is enabled by the presence of a media system; and (3) it presents itself to social actors as a realm of simulation. However, commercial intertextuality is not simply related to the kind of reflexive small-batch production predominantly referred to in discussions of reflexive accumulation. It is also nurtured by the image-loaded commodity concepts of huge media conglomerates.

In the first instance, specialized media are employed as a tool for producing rapid alterations in styles and tastes, quenching the audience's desire not to get stuck in clear-cut, i.e. obsolete, socio-cultural positions. A good example is the small Canadian Urban Juice & Soda Company, manufacturers of Jones Soda, which in 1999 was the fastest growing company in the North American beverage industry. In contrast to most other (bigger) firms, this producer does not invest hundreds of millions of dollars in creating *one* coherent image, appealing to *everyone*, around a beverage that is

virtually identical to that of its competitors, but rather encourages its customers to take part in the development and marketing of the product, which they themselves eventually consume. Except for using weird customer-submitted slogans in their print ads (such as 'We took the best things in life and kept them. You can have this.'). Urban Juice & Soda also developed the concept of using submitted photographs on soft-drink bottles. Hence, the labels are replaced continuously, as are the tastes. So far they have included everything from cherry, lemon–lime and root beer to blue bubble-gum and hot-dog-and-mustard. The manager, Peter van Stolk, would also like to do cheeseburger, because 'then we could use that old Saturday Night Live bit: "No Coke, no Pepsi, just cheeseburger"'. Moreover, in their ambition to turn the consumer into the producer, the company is also applying the new communicative potentials of the internet. The user has the opportunity of uploading a photo, designing a label, and a few days later receiving a personally branded batch of pop (Watson, 1999). Urban Juice & Soda is thus a manifestation of many of the key elements of reflexive accumulation: the consumer as producer, product specialization and volatility, and intertextuality. As to the latter, one single soda bottle, as a sign, may contain an entire network of intertextual relations.

However, this scenario must be supplemented by an account of conglomeration within the culture industries. As political economists have argued over the last 35 years or so, major parts of the culturalized economy are characterized by mergers, take-overs and joint ventures, leading to the establishment of larger and larger conglomerates (e.g. Murdock and Golding, 1973; Bagdikian, 1983; Mattelart et al., 1984; Garnham, 1990; Golding and Murdock, 1996; Herman and McChesney, 1997). Of particular interest are the new opportunities for *product diversification* and *cross-over marketing* that emerge through mergers and take-overs. As Garnham (1990) notes, there is a quite obvious logic to this tendency, based on the fact that all kinds of product development and implementation involve great risks of economic failure (pp. 161–2). Experiences show that market success cannot be predicted with any certainty (see also Mattelart et al., 1984; Mattelart, 1988). Particularly in contexts where developmental costs are high and the logic of audience maximization dominates, the total risk has to be spread out over a range of products and product categories.

The consequences in terms of commercial intertextuality stem from the implementation of multi-product concepts, within which each cultural product both generates surplus value and contributes to the marketing of other products within the concept. For example, the Swedish TV channel, TV3 – part of the media conglomerate, Modern Times Group (MTG) – is

currently quite successful with their daily docu-soap *Baren* (The Bar). The participants run a bar, and are successively voted out by each other and the TV viewers. Via live cameras the programme can also be watched on ZTV, as well as on their web page at Everyday.com – both part of MTG. The voting procedures are governed by the MTG-owned telephone operator, Comviq. The bar is located at Gamla Stans Bryggerier (a brewing company), owned by MTG, and the beer produced at Gamla Stans Bryggerier is advertised by means of the *Baren* signature on Radio RIX (MTG). There are also drink books and CDs produced under the same brand. In addition, the producer – Strix Television (MTG) – now exports the entire *Baren* concept to foreign buyers. This is a typical example of how media conglomerates attempt to create profitable webs of intertextuality.

Another good example, of course, is the Walt Disney Company, the second largest media firm after AOL Time Warner. Ever since the 1950s, Disney has undertaken the meshing of mass-media texts, merchandising and promotion, gathering a line of self-referential products under one coherent concept, which is always a media narrative. Even though filmed entertainment constitutes a major share of the revenues, more than 50 percent actually comes from consumer products and theme parks (Wasko, 1996; Herman and McChesney, 1997). As Garnham (1990) puts it:

... a film may only need hardly to break even in cinemas if its mere exhibition and associated publicity can generate sufficient book, record and merchandising sales, while at the same time the distribution of books, records, T-shirts and toys can create an atmosphere of 'want-to-see' for the film. (p. 202)

Thus, what is at stake here, paradoxically, is the *materialization* of media texts – a promotion strategy where *themed* goods and experiences contribute to the overall strengthening of the movie concept. The foremost location of this phenomenon is in the great theme parks (Disneyland, in Anaheim, California, being the first one in the 1950s), where audiences–customers can walk around in 'real' three-dimensional spaces, looking at well-known figures, reviving well-known narratives, and buy various kinds of themed merchandise. Such media-governed spaces (also represented by themed arcades, cafes and retail stores in metropolitan areas) are the ultimate manifestations of commercial intertextuality at work, commercial intertextuality being their very principle of functioning (see also Zukin, 1991; Davis, 1999; Ritzer, 1999).

Considering these two tendencies together – recognizing the emergence of small flexible firms on the one hand (such as Urban Juice & Soda)

and the increased conglomeration and diversification on the other (such as the Disney empire) – what they have in common is the growing importance of the media in supporting the marketing and distribution of novelties. Thus, in their day-to-day lives, people experience a continuous flow of images composed of media texts, advertising and commodities – categories which, furthermore, collapse into one another. It is no longer obvious what is image and what is product; what is promotion and what is the object of promotion. And through the operation of commercial intertextuality, media-generated images are constantly leaking into the lifeworld in one shape or another.

The everyday context

Extending these discussions, one may easily slip into a postmodern kind of media determinism, arguing that commercial intertextuality exhausts social life. However, what is missing in the postmodernist notion of image culture – as expressed for example in Jameson's (1991) writings on 'depthless culture' and Baudrillard's (1983b) theory of the implosion of meaning in the media – is an account of how the webs of self-referential images are experienced, decoded and re-encoded in everyday life (see Fiske, 1996; Silverstone, 1999: 9). Quite frankly, Jameson's consideration of reception processes stops at the discussion of how the world of media texts, through the blurring of the lines between the real and the imaginary, has altered people's ability for cognitive mapping: that is, their ability to think of themselves as located in cultural and social spaces (Jameson, 1991: 51–4). In a similar manner, Baudrillard's view contends that audiences are turned into masses through the overproduction of spectacular, meaningless signs; a process through which all sociality evaporates.

These arguments may not be entirely misleading. But since both Jameson and Baudrillard overlook the authority of interpretative subjects, as well as the significance of the contexts in which interpretations are made, their theories are somewhat media deterministic, sharing one of the core problems of the Marxist media imperialism thesis: the paradoxical neglect of the cultural patterns that industrially produced (North American) media images are supposed to wipe out.

The main point of my critique is that commercial intertextuality does not operate in isolation; the culture industries cannot in any straightforward manner prescribe how meanings are to be composed. Nor do products/texts take on meanings by themselves; the fixation (however temporary) of cultural meaning is established through interpretations made by *consumers in contexts*. All intertextual inscriptions depend upon the

interpretation of the subject; they must be 'discovered' and confronted with the subject's cultural frame of reference in order to (perhaps) function in the way intended by the industrial encoders.

By extension, this means that image culture is not an arrangement in which consumers/audiences are passive, manipulated dupes unable to think beyond the apparent logic of images, or to reflect upon the productive sources behind the image structure. On the contrary, *image culture presupposes precisely the cultural creativity of interpreting subjects*. Following Hall's (1980) encoding–decoding model, their ability to associate one text with another is just as important for the circuit of cultural production and reproduction as the practices and competencies of the culture industries – which is also a core argument regarding reflexive accumulation. This does not mean that the audience can escape, or exclude, the code systems in which particular texts operate, or that human hermeneutic creativity by definition neutralizes the inscriptions of dominant ideologies. It means that the operation of commercial intertextuality is a negotiated business, just as any other form of meaning production. Consumption is simultaneously a matter of decoding (interpretation) and re-encoding (expression).

Accordingly, the social significance of commercial intertextuality cannot be deduced from mere examinations of particular image structures, no matter how 'close' these readings may be. Analysing image culture is not a matter of studying the transitory characteristics of media texts and commodities (cultural *products*), but rather of studying how these transformations are intertwined with people's everyday *practices* and the structure of cultural *communities*. Clearly, insights from media ethnography and reception studies may help form a more empirical approach here.

Schematically, I would like to distinguish between three different contexts that are important for how a particular commodity-as-text is ascribed cultural meaning (Figure 1). First, as outlined earlier, the meaning is dependent upon the object's relationship to an *intertextual context*. While some external textual phenomena may be embedded in the text (in positive or negative terms), others may be absent. In order to understand how such relationships can actually make sense, it is important to study not only the pattern of intertextuality, but also how the interpretative subject is related to that pattern, as well as to other texts. That is, one has to grasp the overall composition of the subject's cultural framework, in terms of knowledge and preferences.

The latter means that one particular text, and its intertextual structure, may be ascribed different meanings within different socio-cultural contexts, according to the variations between interpretative communities. To use an

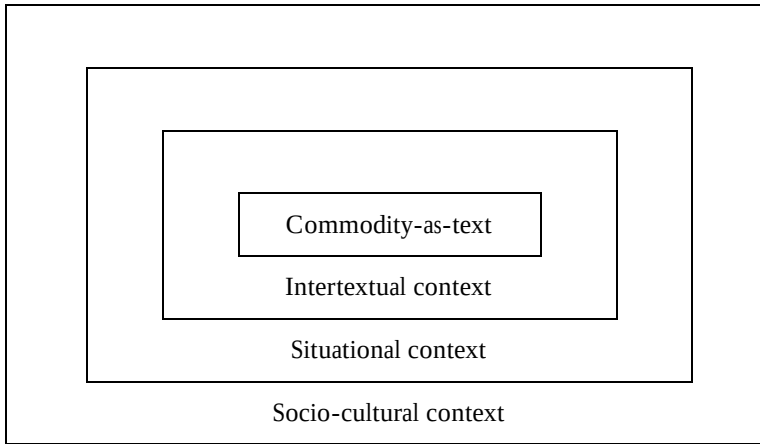


Figure 1: The contexts of commercial intertextuality

example from audience studies, in a cross-cultural reception analysis of readings of *Dallas*, Liebes and Katz (1990) could discern several explanations of why the series did not become successful in Japan. One explanation was that the viewers' genre expectations diverged from what the programme actually turned out to be. Most of them wanted to read *Dallas* as a 'home drama', that is, according to how a home drama is generally constructed in Japan. *Dallas* was considered to be too violent, involving too many parallel stories, and without any real solutions. Since the intertextual composition of the programme was 'misinterpreted', the narrative became hard to follow and make sense of in a positive way.

However, one does not have to travel across the globe in order to reveal interpretative variations. All individuals are part of a whole range of different communities at the same time, experiencing a sense of multiple cultural identity. And whatever these cultural referents are – in terms of occupation, religion, lifestyles, and so on – they have a potential influence upon interpretation.

Finally, the meanings of texts vary between different situational contexts. Due to culturally established conventions – which have been studied in detail by ethnomethodologists (e.g. Goffman, 1959; Garfinkel, 1984[1967]) – one and the same behaviour and hence one and the same object is interpreted differently as the immediate social and material contexts alter. Ethnographic media studies have clearly demonstrated that the social networks in which texts are actually consumed play a significant part

in determining how cultural and social meanings are ascribed to them (see Lull, 1990; Silverstone and Hirsh, 1992; Tufte, 2001).

Furthermore, although promotional strategies aim to locate commodities properly within all these contexts – through design, advertising and market segmentation – images are never fixed or independent of the dynamics of social life. When trying to understand the logic of image culture it is thus necessary to stress the importance of *time*. Since contexts themselves fluctuate, a pattern of intertextuality is not a stable construction. The potential meanings of the textual elements that one text may contain or refer to are themselves changing since these texts are embedded in changing contexts too. In other words, it is impossible to find any absolute stability here. The meaning of objects can change from one period of time to another, encoded texts may be re-encoded – a transitory process including both particular objects-as-texts and entire product categories, or genres.

CONCLUSION

Image culture can be defined as a social arrangement in which media culture and consumer culture are no longer separable categories, and where media images and media influenced commodity-signs are to an increasing extent used as sources for, and expressions of, identity. These expressions, in turn, contribute to the reproduction of cultural categorizations which, in a specific period of time, are shared within a certain (although often vaguely demarcated) cultural community and are relevant within a certain situational context of consumption.

To speak of image culture, then, is not to speak about hyperreality, or the implosion of meaning. While the boundaries between image and reality, between imagination and direct experience, might be increasingly blurred and material use-value is eroding, this is not the whole picture. Recapitulating the discussions in this article, there are two fundamental arguments to be made. First, since hyperreality, in Baudrillard's view, leads to the implosion of the social, it is by definition an anti-cultural hypothesis; and if we deny the hermeneutic nature of people's everyday praxis, there is no way of estimating the socio-cultural consequences of an assumed hyperreality. Second, image culture has emerged and maintains itself according to the logic of capitalism, extended into a mode of reflexive accumulation. Hence, it is grounded in very 'real', material conditions.

Thus, while the notion of hyperreality is based upon an empirical rejection of both production and consumption contexts, the concept of image culture points to the integral set of social, cultural and economic processes fusing these spheres closer together, making image a matter of continuous

hermeneutic negotiation and contest. As an object of study, image culture corresponds to the empirical tradition of cultural studies, turning post-modern ambivalences into a researchable field. And there is no doubt that new alliances between media studies and consumption studies can help us in getting this work done.

Notes

1. The empirical work is presented in my dissertation, 'Image Culture: Media, Consumption and Everyday Life in Reflexive Modernity' (Jansson, 2001a).
2. Fruitful discussions of the media concept are provided by Silverstone et al. (1992) and Bjurström et al. (2000). For example, following Silverstone et al. (1992), one may regard 'media products' as the products of all kinds of media institutions, thus including both media content (texts) and technologies. Since it is often hard to distinguish between text and technology, content and mediator, it is reasonable to treat both aspects as media products: both the text in the magazine and the magazine itself; both the music of the CD and the disk itself; both the TV programme and the TV set, and so on (see also Bjurström et al., 2000: 75–81). The concept of consumption is discussed for example in Slater (1997) and Bjurström et al. (2000).
3. Good examples of contextualizing media ethnography can be found in Morley (1986, 1992), Lull (1990), Silverstone and Hirsch (1992), Moores (1996), Ang (1995), Gillespie (1996), Andersson and Jansson (1998), Gauntlett and Hill (1999), Jansson (2000) and Tufte (2000).
4. The influences of the commercial media sphere upon public service corporations have been discussed by, for example, Garnham (1990: 115–35), Syvertsen (1991), Murdock (1992), Scannell (1992), Sparks (1995) and Sondergaard (1999).

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André Jansson is a lecturer in the School of Arts and Communication at Malmö University. His main research interests include audience and consumption studies, theories of lifestyle and identity formation, and globalization and urban theory. He has recently published a chapter in *Contested Meanings: Audience Studies and the Concept of Cultural Identity*, edited by Ullamaija Kivikuru (Nordicom, 2001) and an article in *Nordicom Review* (2000). Address: School of Arts and Communication, Malmö University, 205 06 Malmö, Sweden. [email: andre.jansson@k3.mah.se]
